

SORN – Level Design Document – Level 1

1. Level Overview

- Level Name: *The Wall*
 - Level Type: (Mission)
 - Player Count: 1
 - Estimated Playtime: 5-8 minutes
 - Primary Player Fantasy: Infiltrate “The Wall,” plant explosives, execute the commander, and escape
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2. Narrative & Context

Story Purpose:

- This level exists because our narrative has taken us to this desert wasteland with direct orders to infiltrate a location called “The Wall” The outer part of the wall, which is a desert, nests a security checkpoint players will go through as a tutorial area before infiltrating the Wall. Inside The Wall, players plant explosives as they move through the sectors. Finally, players execute the “Commander,” and escape as the explosives go off.

Narrative Beats:

- Beat 1: “Getting Online” which is our stationary tutorial
 - Beat 2: Clearing out the security checkpoint to get comfortable with the controls
 - Beat 3: Infiltrating the wall via a side vent, and entering room 1
 - Beat 4: Defeating enemies in sector 1, and progressing to sector 2
 - Beat 5: Defeating the enemies in sector 2, and progressing to the boss room
 - Beat 6: Engage in boss fight with the commander and defeat him
 - Beat 7: Escape down the hatch and exit through the front door (previously locked) and escape in your hub ship (cutscene)
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3. Player Goals & Objectives

Primary Objectives: Defeating the Commander of the Wall

Secondary/Optional Objectives:

- Complete the tutorial
- Clear out enemies at security checkpoint
- Clear out sector 1
- Clear out sector 2

Fail Conditions: Losing all health results in death, resetting player to previous checkpoint

Success Conditions: Progressing to the next beat is possible (doors unlock)

4. Level Flow & Structure

Entry Point: Drop in via hub ship

Critical Path Summary:

1. Complete tutorial
2. Clear security checkpoint
3. Clear out sectors 1 and 2
4. Defeat the boss

Exit Point: Through the initially locked front door

5. Combat Design

Combat Style: Open arena, chokepoints, ambushes, vertical combat,

Enemy Types: Turret, drones, hermit, laser turret, opposing mech

Enemy Placement Philosophy: Enemies are placed strategically for balance as well as **breadcrumbing**

Encounter Progression:

1. Encounter 1: Checkpoint enemies flow from front to back leading to the vent in the wall
2. Encounter 2: Strategically placed enemies flow from right to left, breadcrumbing the player to the door. Additionally, enemies are placed keeping in mind variety and balance
3. Encounter 3: Enemies flow from front to back and are also placed on the side of the players, enabling 360-degree combat. Verticality is introduced via jump pads allowing for further traversal
4. Encounter 4: Boss fight combines everything learned into a fight against another mech

Difficulty Ramp: More enemies faced as level progresses, as well as variety

6. Exploration & Navigation

Traversal Mechanics:

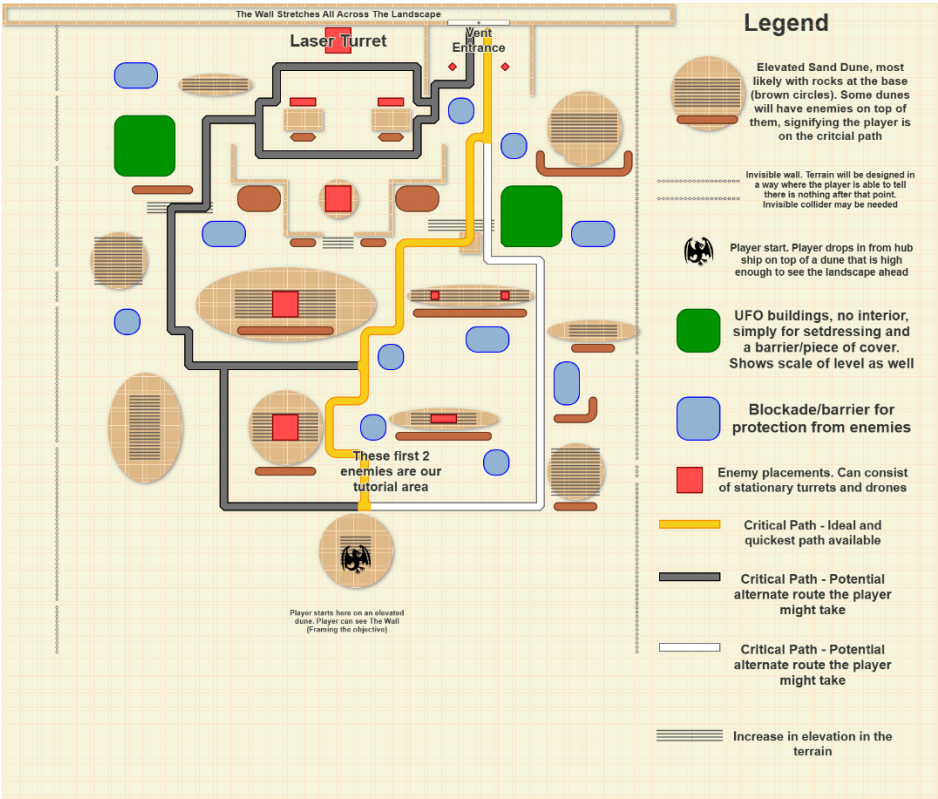
- Jumping
- Upward thrusting
- Boosting state
- Dash

Landmarks & Wayfinding: Objective markers with distance

Secrets / Optional Paths: None

Risk vs Reward Elements: Limited amount of rockets and heals per level

7. Level Layout (Top-Down Description)



Legend



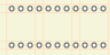
Player



Enemy Boss



Platform(s)/Potential spot for our bouncepads



Train



Critical Path



Increase in Elevation - Nodes stacked above each other indicate another change in elevation



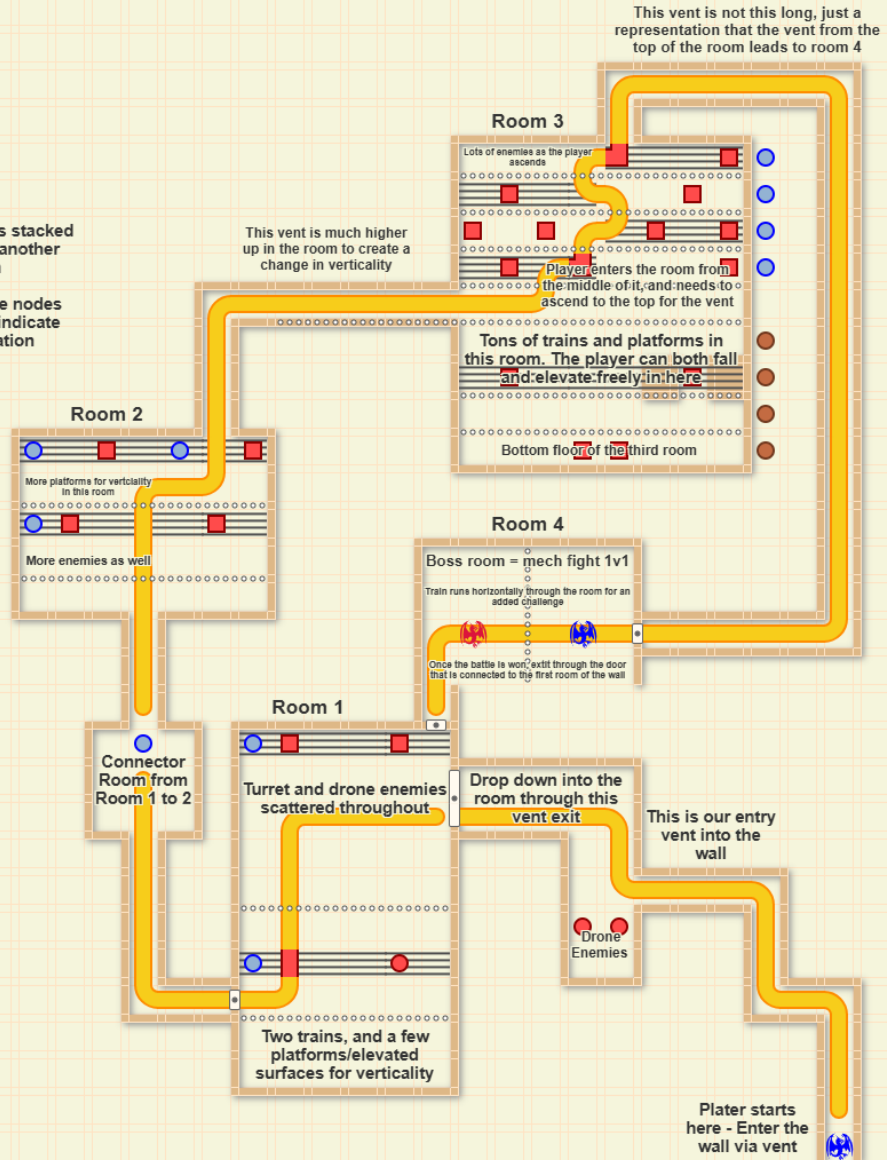
Decrease in elevation - Blue nodes stacked above each other indicate another change in elevation



Enemy/Enemies



Marked door - Vent



9. Environmental Storytelling

Visual Themes: Art style not finalized

- Set Dressing Goals: Spaces should feel lived in, but props should also be placed with logical reasoning. Additionally, all props/pieces of cover should be placed strategically to allow for balanced engagements, encourage aggressive gameplay, provide proper sightlines, and verticality where needed while maintaining visual interest and cohesion

Implied Events:

Play space is currently occupied by opposing faction, and is an operational shipping facility using trains to transport cargo throughout the wall

10. Technical Considerations

Performance Targets: Perfect 60 FPS

Streaming / Level Partitioning: Level streaming is used to load/unload levels not needed. Additionally, it is used so we can work in the same level at the same time in engine

Blueprint / System Dependencies: Enemy BP, Mech BP, Train BP and splines

Known Risks: Different designers working on same levels can cause creative differences, or result in a level that is not cohesive

11. Player Experience Goals

Intended Emotions: Exhilaration and satisfaction

Pacing Notes: Tutorial is tame, but once the player approaches the checkpoint the pace increases substantially. Downtime exists between encounters but only for brief stints.

Moments to Remember: Final boss fight vs the Commander of the Wall

12. Metrics & Testing Notes

Time to Complete: 5-8 minutes

Death Hotspots: Laser turret guarding the entrance to the wall

Player Confusion Points:

- Understanding that players can only progress when their current objective is complete
- There is no backtracking
- All mechanics in tutorial should be spoon fed and applied in the level at some point

Iteration Notes: Images, design process, and thought process should be presented in the #level chat and explained thoroughly. This includes intentions, concepts, future changes, and any assets/systems that need to be made or implemented for the next iteration

13. Open Questions / To-Do

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